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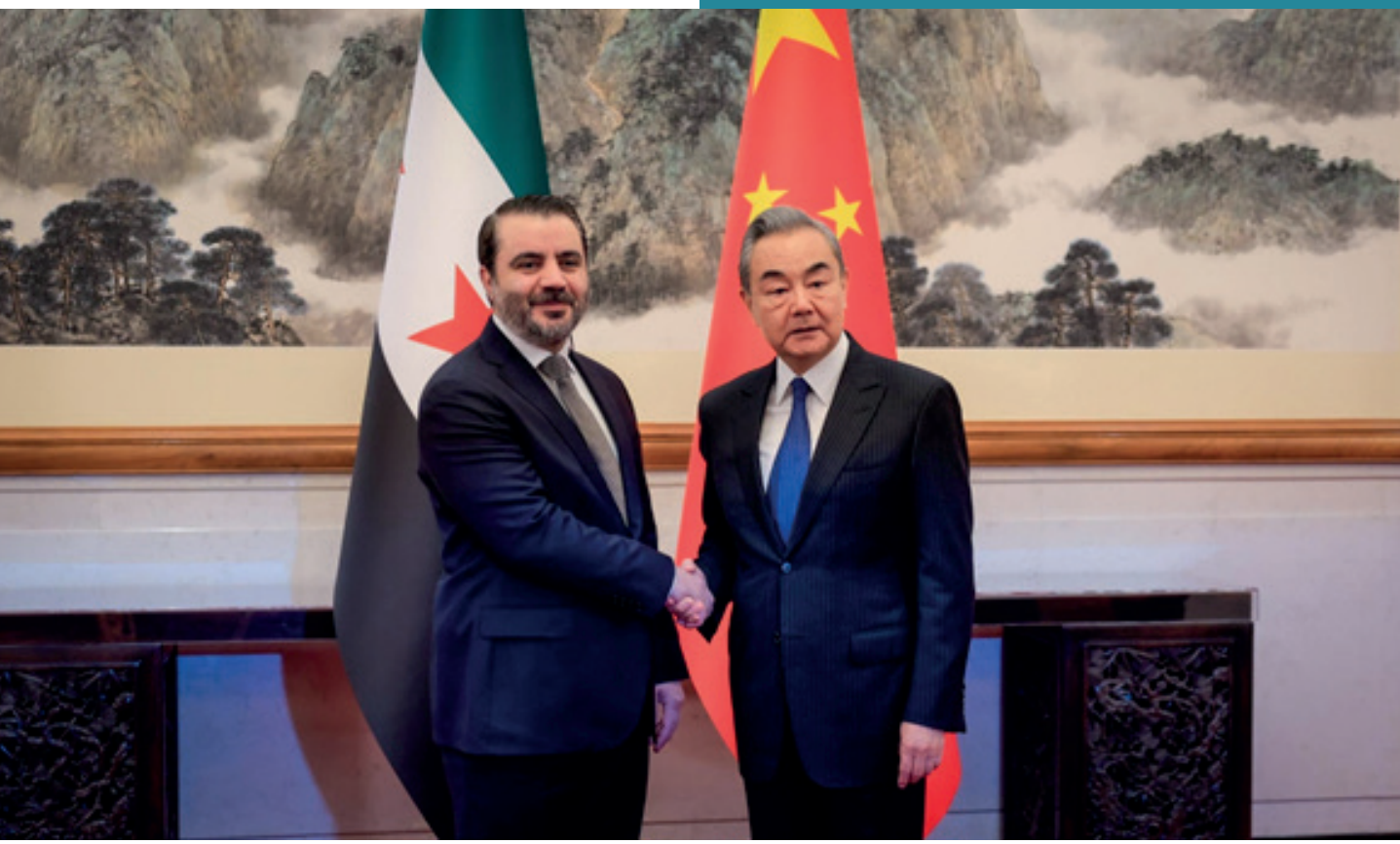

FROM CAUTION TO ENGAGEMENT: CHINA'S SHIFT TOWARD THE NEW SYRIA

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For months, China kept Syria at arm's length, limiting its engagement with the country's new leadership to only a handful of meetings. While much of the world moved to embrace the new Syria, Beijing lagged behind, opting instead for a cautious wait-and-see approach and avoiding deeper political or economic involvement. This hesitation stemmed largely from security concerns over Uyghur militants operating in Syria, along with persistent doubts about the country's long-term stability and the slow pace of sanctions relief. Now, however, with the Syrian government signaling its readiness

Syrian President Ahmad al-Sharaa meets with Chinese Ambassador Shi Hongwei in Damascus, Syria, Feb. 22, 2025. (SANA)

for deeper cooperation on the issue of foreign fighters and the Trump administration determined to lift sanctions, Beijing appears to be recalibrating its Syria policy. The Syrian foreign minister's recent visit to China stands as the clearest indication yet of this shift. Despite its initial caution, China now seems prepared to upgrade bilateral ties on both diplomatic and economic fronts. The pace and depth of this process, however, will depend largely on how effectively Syria addresses the issue of foreign fighters, whether it can sustain internal stability, and whether sanctions can be lifted permanently and unconditionally.

CHINA'S CONCERNS TO EASE AS FOREIGN FIGHTERS INTEGRATE

After the fall of the Bashar Assad regime, a diplomatic flurry began as regional and international actors rushed to Damascus to establish contact with the new Syrian government. Among the major powers, Russia moved fastest, seeking to preserve its military assets, while the U.S. followed suit, eager to draw Syria into its sphere of influence. Yet nearly a year into the regime's collapse, China remained the most hesitant, choosing to stay largely on the sidelines. Beijing's caution was driven primarily by the presence of Uyghur militants within the ranks of the Turkistan Islamic Party (TIP). Estimated at 3,000 to 5,000 strong, these fighters were among the most battle-hardened elements of Hayat Tahrir al-Sham (HTS) and played a key role in toppling the Assad regime. But TIP's ideological hostility toward China long made the group anathema to Beijing, which views it as a direct national-security threat. Unwilling to fully recognize a government whose military ranks included TIP fighters, China kept its engagement to a minimum and focused on ensuring that these militants would pose no risk to its security.

This cautious approach, however, did not prevent China from establishing channels of communication with the new Syrian authorities. Beijing understood that containing foreign

fighters and mitigating potential security threats would be possible only through direct engagement with Damascus. With this in mind, several Chinese delegations visited Syria, the most notable of which was the Chinese ambassador's meeting with President Ahmad al-Sharaa in February.[1] Yet these early contacts produced few tangible results. The Syrian government was unwilling to take decisive action against foreign fighters, who had played a crucial role in the regime's overthrow and were now poised to become an integral component of the new Syrian army. Any attempt to dismantle or marginalize them risked undermining Syria's already fragile security, especially at a moment when jihadist groups like DAESH/ISIS were already exploiting al-Sharaa's pragmatic tilt toward the West. Although al-Sharaa repeatedly assured the international community that Syria would not become a base from which foreign fighters could threaten regional or global actors, his government maintained that the most viable strategy was to integrate these factions into the national army and to ensure they abandoned any transnational jihadist ambitions.

The establishment of the 84th Division of the Syrian army marked an important step in this direction. After receiving a green light from the U.S., Damascus moved to bring foreign fighters under formal state authority by integrating them into the Ministry of Defense through the newly created 84th Division.[2] Although Washington had first insisted that Syria expel these fighters, it eventually acknowledged that the most practical solution was not expulsion but controlled integration. This meant ensuring the fighters' loyalty, placing them under a unified chain of command, and embedding them within the national army. This approach allowed Syrian authorities to register each fighter and closely monitor their activities. In practice, this meant that any faction that refused to comply with state policies would be neutralized, a method al-Sharaa had already been applying diligently against unruly jihadist groups as well as DAESH and al-Qaeda remnants in Idlib between 2017 and 2024.

This is also a formula China could work with. According to the press readout of the Syrian foreign minister's meeting with his Chinese counterpart, this

Syria has pledged not to allow any group on its territory to threaten China's national security and agreed to deepen security and counterterrorism coordination. For its part, China is no longer insisting on their expulsion, let alone their handover to Chinese authorities.

1 "Syria's new president meets Chinese envoy for first time since Assad's fall", *Al Arabiya*, 21 February 2025.

2 Timour Azhari and Suleiman al-Khalidi, "Exclusive: US gives nod to Syria to bring foreign jihadist ex-rebels into army", *Reuters*, 2 June 2025.

understanding now seems to form the basis of their mutual approach to foreign fighters.[3] Syria has pledged not to allow any group on its territory to threaten China's national security and agreed to deepen security and counterterrorism coordination. For its part, China is no longer insisting on their expulsion, let alone their handover to Chinese authorities. Under this arrangement, TIP fighters will remain in Syria, be a part of the Syrian military structure, and stay under the strict control of the central government. And those who fail to comply with state policies will face necessary measures.

The case of Franco-Senegalese jihadist Omar Diaby illustrates how this policy would play out on the ground. Leading a group of foreign fighters in a camp in Idlib, Diaby has refused to integrate into the Syrian army and frequently criticizes al-Sharaa for abandoning the implementation of sharia law and for adopting a more pro-Western orientation.[4] Whether to appease the French government or simply to enforce state authority, Syrian security forces launched an operation against his camp on October 21.[5] Although the confrontation ended in a ceasefire, the crackdown demonstrated the Syrian authorities' readiness to use force against rogue jihadist elements that refuse to submit to state control. The same fate will await any foreign fighters who threaten China's national security. After all, the international legitimacy of Damascus and its relations with Beijing will be closely linked to how effectively it can counter the potential threats posed by foreign fighters.

Al-Sharaa's meeting with U.S. President Donald Trump also played a key role in easing Chinese concerns and contributed to the recent thaw in bilateral relations. Following the White House talks, Syria officially joined the U.S.-led Global Coalition against DAESH, formalizing what was already an emerging counterterrorism partnership.[6] Far from symbolic, this step was highly significant. The Syrian leadership publicly demonstrated its willingness to combat terrorism on its territory in cooperation with the U.S. It also sent a signal to the international community, including China, that the Syrian government intends to take counterterrorism seriously and will not allow foreign fighters to operate freely or undermine international security. The cumulative effect of these developments was that Beijing felt confident enough to agree to a ministerial-level meeting and begin a thaw in bilateral relations.

BEIJING POISED FOR ECONOMIC ENGAGEMENT AS OBSTACLES LIFT

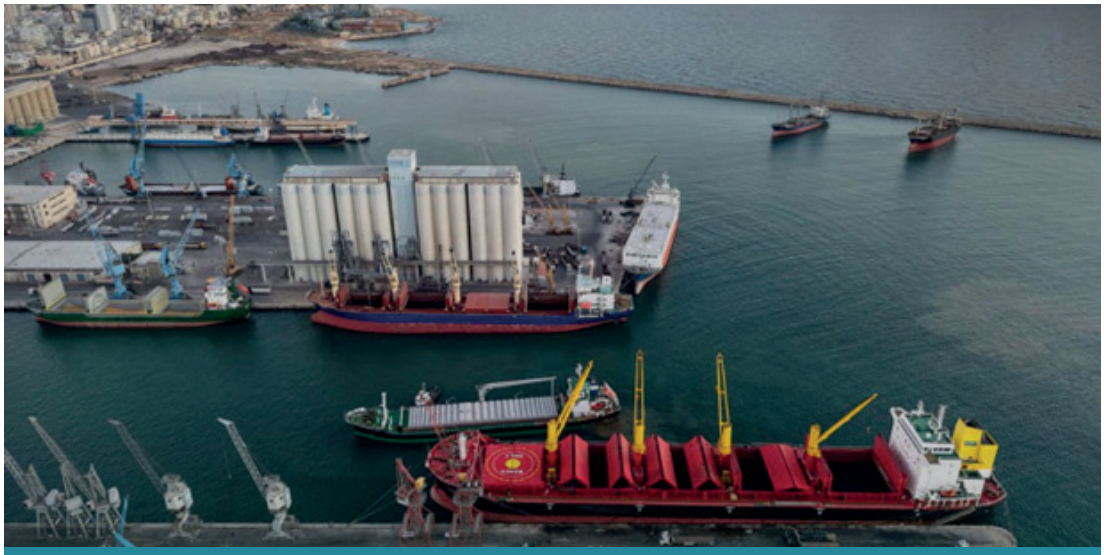
Mirroring its cautious diplomatic posture, China also refrained from launching major investment or reconstruction initiatives in Syria, opting instead to delay meaningful economic engagement. Although several large-scale projects were announced, thanks in large part to growing Gulf involvement, Beijing largely remained on the sidelines, maintaining a wait-and-see approach before committing to substantial investments. Beyond its national security concerns, China's hesitation stemmed

3 "Wang Yi Holds Talks with Minister of Foreign Affairs and Expatriates of the Syrian Transitional Government Asaad Hassan al-Shaibani", *Ministry of Foreign Affairs – People's Republic of China*, 17 November 2025.

4 Daham al-Assad and Guillaume Perrier, "Omar Diaby: The French Jihadist Who Retired in Idlib", *Daraj*, 3 April 2025.

5 Abby Sewell, "What to know about the French militants who clashed with Syrian forces in Idlib", *The Associated Press*, 23 October 2025.

6 "Syria signs up to US-led coalition against ISIL", *Al Jazeera*, 11 November 2025.



Syria receives a direct shipment from China carrying steel and various equipment, Tartous Port, Syria, Oct. 26, 2025. (SANA)

from the slow pace of progress on domestic stability and sanctions relief. For Beijing, meaningful participation in Syria's reconstruction will only be possible once the country begins to function as a "normal" state, one in which political and economic conditions are stable enough to ensure that Chinese investments will not be jeopardized by persistent internal or external volatility.

International sanctions remain the primary obstacle discouraging China from deeper economic engagement in Syria. As a country that prefers to operate firmly within the boundaries of international trade regulations, Beijing wants airtight assurances that sanctions will be permanently and unconditionally lifted before committing major investments. In May, U.S. President Trump announced his intention to remove sanctions on Syria, and since then, the administration has taken important steps in that direction. Most recently, Washington issued a 180-day waiver suspending the Caesar Act sanctions.[7] While significant, these measures still fall short of providing the permanent legal certainty that Chinese companies require. For full investor confidence, the U.S. Senate would need to repeal the Caesar sanctions altogether. Given the Trump administration's stated commitment to lifting sanctions and the positive outcomes of al-Sharaa's recent meetings in Washington, the prospect of a permanent repeal has become more plausible than ever. Should that occur, Chinese firms are expected to participate energetically in Syria's reconstruction, no longer constrained by the risk of secondary sanctions or legal exposure.

Syria's fragile stability constitutes another major obstacle to China's economic engagement. Although there was initial optimism that the country would stabilize after the regime's collapse, those hopes quickly faded as sectarian unrest flared in Latakia and Suwayda. The slow pace of political stabilization and na-

7 Muhammed Yasin Güngör, "US partially suspends Caesar Act sanctions on Syria for 180 days", *Anadolu Agency*, 10 November 2025.

tional reconciliation has raised doubts among risk-averse Chinese investors, who prefer to see a certain level of security and predictability before committing capital. Nevertheless, with sustained U.S. backing for the transitional government and Washington's clear interest in Syria's stability, conditions may gradually shift toward a more investor-friendly environment. Meanwhile, levels of violence have steadily declined in recent months, reaching "an all-time low" since the revolution and once again generating optimism about Syria's future security trajectory.[8] Taken together, these dynamics have given Beijing stronger incentives to recalibrate its approach and engage more closely with the new authorities, particularly on the economic front. If stability holds in Syria, China could move rapidly into reconstruction and development projects, compensating for its late entry and establishing itself as a key player in the country's economic future, much as it did in post-conflict Iraq.

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The World Bank estimates that rebuilding Syria after the 14-year civil war will cost roughly $216 billion.[9] The country urgently needs large-scale investment to restore its shattered infrastructure, and support will be welcome from any capable partner. With its substantial financial resources and highly developed reconstruction expertise, China is well-positioned to meaningfully contribute to Syria's recovery. Seeking to secure a share of major post-war projects, particularly in energy and infrastructure, Beijing is unlikely to miss the opportunity to establish a stronger economic foothold. Syria already joined the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) in 2022, though the civil war prevented significant Chinese investment from materializing.[10] Now that the conflict has ended, China can finally begin directing much-needed investment into Syria and play a constructive role in the country's rebuilding. Doing so would not only advance China's economic interests but also enable Beijing to gain strategic benefits in a country located at the heart of the Middle East, helping counterbalance Syria's gradual drift toward Western influence.

Crucially, U.S. involvement in Syria does not necessarily pose a major impediment to Chinese

8 Charles R. Lister, "Data Update (November 11-18)", *Syria Weekly*, 20 November 2025.

9 "Syria's Post-Conflict Reconstruction Costs Estimated at $216 billion", *World Bank Group*, 21 October 2025.

10 Sarah Shamim, "Al-Assad's fall in Syria: What's at stake for China?", *Al Jazeera*, 11 December 2024.

engagement. While Washington is wary of an expanded Chinese presence, the two powers ultimately share a core interest in a stable Syria, and their competition will play out in political and economic arenas rather than the military domain, where China has no intention of becoming a stakeholder.[11] Although closer Syria-China ties may generate frictions in Damascus's relations with Washington, Syria still has room to maneuver to manage this balancing act. Understandably, the new government will seek to avoid overreliance on any single major power and instead diversify its partnerships by engaging simultaneously with the U.S., Russia, and China. In practice, an implicit division of labor may emerge: the Americans prioritizing military and security issues, and the Chinese focusing on economic engagement, development, and reconstruction.[12] Such an arrangement could prove mutually beneficial for both Washington and Beijing. Most importantly, it would allow Syria to maximize the advantages of great-power involvement, precisely as it should.

CONCLUSION

Syrian Foreign Minister Asaad Hassan al-Shaibani's meeting with his Chinese counterpart took place on November 17 against this backdrop and marked a clear turning point in China-Syria relations. According to the press readout, security and economic issues dominated the agenda, and the statement suggests that both sides reached a pragmatic, win-win understanding.[13] Syria would ensure that no actor on its territory threatens China's security interests, while China would provide diplomatic backing and economic support as Syria advances its reconstruction and reintegration into the international system.

Beyond security considerations, China also has clear geopolitical and economic interests in Syria as it seeks to expand its influence in the Middle East. Beijing aims to secure a strategic foothold in a region where it increasingly competes with the West, particularly the U.S. With Syrian-U.S. relations now largely restored, China is eager not to fall behind and wants to ensure that Syria does not drift fully into the Western orbit. At the same time, Beijing is looking to obtain a share of lucrative reconstruction contracts and convert its economic engagement into long-term political and strategic influence, as it has done in other parts of the world. With Syria moving toward greater stability and U.S. sanctions expected to be lifted, conditions appear increasingly favorable for China to launch an investment program to support the country's reconstruction. China's decision to begin sending container shipments to Syria marks this shift in bilateral economic relations.[14]

This evolving Chinese posture toward Syria is matched by Damascus' own strategic calculations. Syria's interest in maintaining good ties with China is driven by several key motivations. First, Damascus seeks financial and investment support for reconstruction, viewing China as one of the most capable powers to provide large-scale capital and technical expertise. Gaining China's confidence holds the promise of unlocking much-needed reconstruction financing. Since the new government

11 Christina al-Shammas, "Beyond the Uyghur file, what does China want in Syria?", *Enab Baladi*, 19 November 2025.

12 Al-Shammas, "Beyond the Uyghur File".

13 "Chinese FM holds talks with Syrian counterpart", *Xinhua*, 17 November 2025.

14 "Tartous Port Strengthens Maritime Trade with Shipment from China", *Syrian Arab News Agency (SANA)*, 27 October 2025.

has closely linked Syria's security and stability to post-war reconstruction, it is eager to attract Chinese investment to advance national development and economic recovery.

Second, alignment with a global actor such as China offers the new government an opportunity to further bolster its international legitimacy. Maintaining strong relations with China, a permanent member of the UN Security Council, can help ensure more favorable outcomes on key UN resolutions within the Security Council. China's abstention in the November vote on removing al-Sharaa from the UN terrorism list shows how Beijing's diplomatic posture can strengthen Syria's international standing.[15]

Finally, cultivating stronger ties with Beijing allows Syria to diversify its external partnerships and avoid excessive dependence on any single bloc—whether it is the West, Russia, or the Gulf states. At a time when Israeli aggression poses the most serious threat to Syria's sovereignty and territorial integrity, China's diplomatic backing, rooted in its consistent emphasis on non-interference and respect for state sovereignty, offers Damascus an additional layer of political support in the face of escalating Israeli interventions.

In light of these considerations, it is evident that both countries stand to gain considerably from deeper political, diplomatic, and economic engagement. Looking ahead, Beijing appears ready to move from a cautious observer to a more active stakeholder in Syria's future. The durability of this emerging partnership, however, will depend on Damascus' ability to consolidate internal stability, control the activities of foreign fighters, and obtain lasting relief from international sanctions. If these conditions are met, the Chinese-Syrian relationship could evolve into an important pillar of Syria's post-conflict recovery and its reemergence as a stable, functional state.

15 Michelle Nichols, "UN Security Council removes sanctions on Syria's president, interior minister", *Reuters*, 7 November 2025.

NOTES

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